disaster, as it mainly served China's interests, although the Indian government's PR machinery heralded it as a triumph for Nehru.

Chinese cartographic aggression began almost immediately after the signing of the treaty. Chinese military garrisons mushroomed all across Tibet, reaching right up to the border with India. Simultaneously, within a couple of months of the agreement, the Chinese began laying claim to areas south of the de facto boundary. It became clear that the Chinese had been misleading the Indians all along. Work on National Highway G219 that was to connect Western Tibet with Sinkiang had begun in 1951 itself. With India having scored a self-goal with the highly vaunted Panchsheel Agreement, to save face, Nehru was left with no choice but to keep the flag of Indo-Chinese friendship flying on the world stage leaving the Chinese free to go about the business of further securing Tibet.

The next phase of the Chinese plan was to stress the fact that the border was not demarcated while at the same time claiming ownership of 36,000 square kilometres in NEFA and another 31,080 square kilometres in Jammu and Kashmir. Nehru broached the subject of the Chinese maps with Chou En-lai when he visited China in October 1954. The Chinese premier dismissed the maps as being of little consequence. Two years later, when it was Chou En-lai's turn to visit New Delhi in November 1956, he once again brushed off the matter. At that time, the Chinese needed another twelve months to complete National Highway G219.

Many observers lay the blame for the 1962 clash at India's doorstep, charging the Nehru-Menon-Kaul troika with provoking the conflict. War with China, even at this early stage, when neither Menon nor Kaul were in the picture, was inevitable. Just as Communist China under Mao had decided that Sinkiang and Tibet were to be annexed for their strategic ends, it had also decided that control over Aksai Chin was a necessity. Nehru proved to be no match for the battle-hardened communist leader. The Kulwant Singh Committee Report—another classified document like the Himmatsinhji Report and the Henderson Brooks-Bhagat Report—not only predicted the clash, it even got the time-frame right. Yet, despite repeated warnings, Nehru would continue to champion China's case for admittance to the United Nations while also preventing a discussion on the annexation of Tibet.

On 17 July 1954, after Chinese troops had crossed the Central Sector passes named in the Panchsheel Treaty, the Consul of China in New Delhi